

RITU CHARYA, THE SEASONAL REGIMEN (UNIT III)

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INTRODUCTION

- *Ritucharya is the ancient Ayurvedic practice and is comprised of two words , 'Ritu' means season and 'charya' means Regimen or discipline.*
- *Ritucharya consists of lifestyle and ayurvedic diet routine to cope with the bodily and mental impacts caused by seasonal changes as recommended by Ayurveda.*
- *Changing seasons have a significant impact on the human body, changes in the climate can cause certain diseases to activated and affect individuals. In Ayurveda, Ritucharyas direct humans to keep themselves protected from diseases that can occur due to climatic changes.*

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- According to Ayurveda, there are six different seasons (ritus) that occur in a year. Each ritu lasts for three months.
 - They are :
 - 1) Sishiram (winter) - mid January to mid March
 - 2) Vasantham (spring) - mid March to mid May
 - 3) Greeshma (summer) - mid May to mid July
 - 4) Varsham (rainy season) - mid July to mid September
 - 5) Sarath (autumn) - mid September to mid November
 - 6) Hemanta (dew) - mid November to mid January

1. Sishiram (winter) - mid January to mid March

During this season , the environment remains cold and windy. The strength of the person remains less in this season.

- **Diet routine** : *foods having Amla (tart) as the overwhelming taste is preferred. Cereals and pulses , wheat / gram flour items, new rice , corn, and others are suggested. Ginger, garlic, sugarcane items , milk and milk items are to be incorporated into the eating regimen. Laghu (light) and Shita (cool) foods should be avoided.*
- **Lifestyle** : *Massage with oil/powder/paste and take shower with tepid water (water that is neither too hot nor too cold, typically between 60 degree F and 100 degree F, exposure to sunlight and wearing warm clothes is essential.*

2. Vasantham (spring) - mid March to mid May

This season is considered as the season of flowers and origin of new leaves. An individual's strength during this season remains in medium degree.

- Diet routine : *one should take foods that are easily digestible. In cereals, wheat , rice , old barley is suggested during this season. In pulses, lentil , Mugda etc. can be eaten. Foods that are cold, heavy and viscous should be avoided.*
- Lifestyle : *using tepid water for bathing is considered ideal. Exercising during vasant ritu is must. Massage with the powder of Chandana, Kesera , Agaru is suggested. Sleeping during day is not advised during this season.*

3. Greeshma (summer) - mid May to mid July

This season is intensely hot and environment is prevalent with unhealthy wind. The lakes and rivers are dried up, the plants are lifeless and the strength of an individual becomes weak.

- **Diet routine** : Foods which are light to process - those having Madhura (Sweet), Sheets (cool), and Drava (fluid), for example rice, lentil, etc should be eaten. Drinking a lot of water and different fluids like cold water, buttermilk. Fruit juices, meat soups, mango juices. At sleep time milk with sugar should be taken.
- **Lifestyle** : remaining in cool spots, applying sandal wood and other aromatic pastes over the body, decorating with blossoms, wearing light dresses and napping at day day time are usual.

4. Varsham (rainy season) - mid July to mid September

During this season , the sky is cloudy and rains happens without thunderstorms. The lakes and rivers are filled with water. The strength of an individual becomes weak in this season.

- Diet routine : foods having Amla (tarty) and Lavana (salty) taste should be eaten. Among grains, old barley , rice , wheat, and so on, are suggested. Soups are to be incorporated into the daily diet. It is said that one should take medicated water or boiled water.

Drinking river water, having a lot od water, excessive fluid and wine should not be taken.

- Lifestyle : boiled water for bathing and massaging the body properly with oil is advised during this season.

5. Sarath (autumn) - mid September to mid November

During this season, the Sun turns out to be splendid, the sky stays clear and sometimes with white clouds, and the earth is smeared with wet mud. The strength and energy of an individual stays medium.

- Diet routine: foods having Madhura (sweet) and Tikta (sharp) taste, and of Laghu (light to process) and cold properties should be eaten. Wheat, green gram, sugar, sweet, is to be incorporated into the eating routine.

Hot, bitter foods are to be stayed away from. The food products such as fat, oils, meat of aquatic creatures, curds should be excluded from the diet amid this season.

- Lifestyle: one should take water sanitized by the beams of sun in day time and beams of moon during the evening for drinking, bathing etc. It is suggested that moon beams in the initial 3 hours of night is favourable for well being.

6. Hemanta (dew) -mid November to mid January

blow of cool breezes begins and chillness is felt. The energy & strength of an individual stays on highest grade

- **Diet routine** : one should eat unctuous , sweet , tasty, and salty foods. Among grains & pulses, new rice, green gram, Masha etc, are suggested to be eaten. Consumption of cold drinks is likewise contraindicated
- **Lifestyle** : exercising body and head massage, utilization of warm water

Atapa - sevana (sunbath), use of Agarū on body, substantial garments , sexual liberality with one accomplice and living in warm paces is suggested . Napping during the day and exposure to strong and cold wind should be avoided.